

# Student Study Planner

A semester-length planner built for the reality of juggling multiple classes -- study-load math, spaced repetition, and daily habits.

*This product contains educational information and templates. Nothing here is professional, legal, tax, or investment advice. Numbers in every worked example are illustrations of a method, not predictions or guarantees.*

## 01 Why study blocks beat cramming

Spaced, focused study sessions consistently outperform marathon cramming sessions for actual long-term retention -- this isn't a productivity slogan, it's one of the more replicated findings in learning research. The reason is straightforward: your brain consolidates new information during the gaps between study sessions, not just during the session itself. A single 6-hour cram session the night before an exam can get you through that exam, but the material is gone within days. Six 1-hour sessions spread across two weeks, covering the same material, produces retention that lasts months.

## 02 Building your weekly schedule

Block out study time the same way you'd block out a class -- as a fixed appointment, not something that happens if there's time left over. For each class, estimate weekly hours needed honestly, factoring in difficulty, not just credit hours: a 3-credit class with weekly problem sets needs more time than a 3-credit class with a single midterm and final.

Class 1: \_\_\_\_\_ Weekly hours needed: \_\_\_\_\_ Difficulty (1-5): \_\_\_\_\_

Class 2: \_\_\_\_\_ Weekly hours needed: \_\_\_\_\_ Difficulty (1-5): \_\_\_\_\_

Class 3: \_\_\_\_\_ Weekly hours needed: \_\_\_\_\_ Difficulty (1-5): \_\_\_\_\_

Class 4: \_\_\_\_\_ Weekly hours needed: \_\_\_\_\_ Difficulty (1-5): \_\_\_\_\_

Class 5: \_\_\_\_\_ Weekly hours needed: \_\_\_\_\_ Difficulty (1-5): \_\_\_\_\_

## 03 Study load calculator

Add up total weekly study hours needed across every class, then compare that against your realistic available hours (total free hours minus work, commute, sleep, and a genuine buffer for rest -- burnout undermines the whole plan). If needed hours exceed available hours by more than a small margin, something has to give before the semester gets ahead of you: fewer commitments, tutoring for the hardest class, or an honest conversation about course load.

### LOAD CHECK

Total weekly hours needed = sum of hours across all classes  
Buffer = Available hours - Total weekly hours needed

Buffer > 5 hours: comfortable  
Buffer 0-5 hours: tight, watch closely  
Buffer < 0: overloaded -- something needs to change

### Worked example: 4 classes, 40 available hours per week

Class A: 10 hrs    Class B: 9 hrs    Class C: 8 hrs    Class D: 9 hrs

Total needed = 10 + 9 + 8 + 9 = 36 hours

Buffer = 40 - 36 = 4 hours    -> tight schedule, watch closely

## 04 Spaced repetition schedule

For material you need to actually remember (not just recognize once on an exam), review it on an expanding schedule rather than only once. A widely used spacing pattern is 1, 3, 7, 16, and 35 days after first learning it -- each review takes only a few minutes if the previous one happened on schedule, because you're refreshing, not relearning from scratch.

### REVIEW SCHEDULE FROM FIRST-STUDY DATE

Review 1: Day + 1

Review 2: Day + 3

Review 3: Day + 7

Review 4: Day + 16

Review 5: Day + 35

### Worked example: topic first studied on September 2

Review 1: September 3

Review 2: September 5

Review 3: September 9

Review 4: September 18

Review 5: October 7

Track your own topics below and fill in the five review dates as you go.

Topic: \_\_\_\_\_ First studied: \_\_\_\_\_ R1: \_\_\_\_\_ R2: \_\_\_\_\_ R3: \_\_\_\_\_ R4: \_\_\_\_\_ R5: \_\_\_\_\_

Topic: \_\_\_\_\_ First studied: \_\_\_\_\_ R1: \_\_\_\_\_ R2: \_\_\_\_\_ R3: \_\_\_\_\_ R4: \_\_\_\_\_ R5: \_\_\_\_\_

Topic: \_\_\_\_\_ First studied: \_\_\_\_\_ R1: \_\_\_\_\_ R2: \_\_\_\_\_ R3: \_\_\_\_\_ R4: \_\_\_\_\_ R5: \_\_\_\_\_

## 05 Assignment deadline tracker

Keep every deadline in one place, reviewed weekly, rather than scattered across syllabi you'll need to dig back through.

Assignment: \_\_\_\_\_ Class: \_\_\_\_\_ Due: \_\_\_\_\_ Est. hours: \_\_\_\_\_ Status: \_\_\_\_\_

Assignment: \_\_\_\_\_ Class: \_\_\_\_\_ Due: \_\_\_\_\_ Est. hours: \_\_\_\_\_ Status: \_\_\_\_\_

Assignment: \_\_\_\_\_ Class: \_\_\_\_\_ Due: \_\_\_\_\_ Est. hours: \_\_\_\_\_ Status: \_\_\_\_\_

Assignment: \_\_\_\_\_ Class: \_\_\_\_\_ Due: \_\_\_\_\_ Est. hours: \_\_\_\_\_ Status: \_\_\_\_\_

## 06 Daily habit tracker

Academic performance is downstream of a handful of unglamorous daily habits. Track these three for two weeks and look honestly at the pattern against how your study sessions actually went that day -- the correlation is usually more obvious than expected.

Day 1: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 2: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 3: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 4: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 5: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 6: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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Day 7: Sleep (hrs) \_\_\_\_ Exercise (Y/N) \_\_\_\_ Screen time before bed (hrs) \_\_\_\_

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## 07 Five evidence-based study techniques

- Active recall -- close the book and try to write out what you remember before checking, rather than re-reading passively. Re-reading feels productive but is one of the weaker methods for actual retention.
- Spaced repetition -- covered in Section 4. Spreading review out beats concentrating it, even at the same total number of hours.
- Interleaving -- mix problem types within a study session rather than doing 20 of the same kind in a row. It feels harder in the moment and produces better long-term learning.
- The Feynman technique -- explain the concept out loud in plain language as if teaching someone else. Wherever you stumble is exactly where your understanding is thin.
- Practice testing -- past exams and practice problems under real time pressure reveal gaps that simply reviewing notes never will.

## 08 Quick reference

Load check: Buffer = Available hours - Total weekly hours needed (aim to stay above 5). Spaced repetition intervals: 1, 3, 7, 16, 35 days after first studying a topic. Track sleep, exercise, and screen time daily alongside study sessions to spot the real pattern behind your best and worst days.